brought cups of water. Sick children were produced before the Padshah so that Akbar could breathe on them and infuse them with his miraculous healing powers. Abu'l Fazl writes that whenever Akbar set off outside the capital, he was always petitioned by crowds who 'ask for lasting bliss, for an upright heart, for advice how best to act, for strength of the body, for enlightenment, for the birth of a son, the reunion of friends, a long life, increase of wealth, elevation in rank, and many other things'.

In the towns and villages along the way, Holi was celebrated with an ecstatic fervour that the somewhat aghast Monserrate wrote about. 'During a space of fifteen days,' wrote the Jesuit, 'they are at liberty freely to cast dust upon themselves and upon whoever passes by. They plaster with mud their own bodies and those of any persons they may meet. They also squirt a red dye out of hollow reeds.'

When they reached Thanesar, Akbar along with Abu'l Fazl and Faizi visited the khanqah of an old and respected Chishti Sufi, Shaikh Jalal al-din. The elderly shaikh, who used to remain lying down and was only semi-conscious because of his great age, asked to be lifted upright to honour the visit of the Padshah, the 'Caliph of the age'. The three men had a long conversation on 'the secrets of Divine Realities and mystical sensibilities' and then, prompted by Akbar, Abu'l Fazl asked the shaikh a question: 'You have spent a long life, and have enjoyed the society of the good. Can you tell of a cure for melancholy?' The melancholy that Abu'l Fazl enquired about may have been that of Akbar himself. The Jesuit priests had also commented on the Padshah's tendency to introspection, saying that 'Akbar was by temperament melancholy', attributing it to the 'falling sickness', or epilepsy, and argued that this was the reason Akbar kept himself constantly busy, occupied, and focused. Akbar, too, once said that 'when his understanding is still undeveloped, man is in constant change of mood: at one time taking joy in festivities, at another sitting disconsolate in the house of mourning. When his vision is raised to higher things, sorrow and joy withdraw.' This tendency to occasional melancholia, and a lingering malaise, may have contributed to what would become a constant quest for revelations and spiritual solace. In Thanesar, Akbar had an emotional discussion with the Sufi shaikh and in the recorded memory of later Chishti tazkiras,[*] Akbar was said to have been so impressed with the shaikh that he even wanted to give up his kingship. The shaikh, however, would have dissuaded him saying: